



— A MENTORSHIP-DRIVEN QUEST —

Guitar *Quest.*

*Daily contact beats occasional intensity.
A field manual for becoming a musician —
one rep, one song, one session at a time.*



APPRENTICE

Tristan · 13

MENTOR

H · Hamilton, ON

ARC

V Lessons · X–XII Weeks

The Way of the Quest

May my prayer be set before you like incense; may the lifting up of my hands be like the evening sacrifice.

— PSALM 141:2

This is the heart of it. The lifting up of hands — over six strings, in a quiet room, on an ordinary evening — can be an offering. We are not learning guitar merely to perform. We are learning a language as old as creation, so that one day the hands know the way without being told, and the heart is free to pour out.

Music is not a subject to be completed. It is a gift, and a tongue. Like any language, it is *caught* more than it is taught — felt before it is understood, sung before it is read, played before it is mastered. Our work is to make space for it to be caught, and to keep showing up while it takes root.

Why we play

Melody and harmony are communication without words — they carry emotion, energy, intention. The strange way a minor chord feels heavier and darker than a major one. The way a progression can open a room or still a storm. We did not invent these patterns; we discovered them. **God gave us music**, and we treat the gift with that kind of reverence.

So we learn to express, not to impress. To converse, not to perform. To sit beside someone in joy or sorrow — or to pour out to the Lord in either — and say with strings what words cannot reach. The skill serves the song; the song serves the heart; the heart, in the end, is lifted up.

"Make a joyful noise to the LORD, all the earth! Serve the LORD with gladness! Come into his presence with singing!"

— PSALM 100:1-2

Why we keep showing up

Here is where consistency earns its place. The *why* is the heart — but on the days the heart feels little, the habit carries us across. Daily contact is not the goal; it is the bridge. Ten minutes a day, five to seven days a week, will build a beginner's hands faster than any weekend marathon — and more importantly, it keeps us *in the room*, where the gift is given and the work takes root.

- **Reps over heroics.** Five honest minutes counts. Always.
- **The return is the practice.** Coming back — after one day, three days, three weeks — is the move. A return is never punished here.
- **Slow is smooth, smooth is fast.** Speed is a side effect of clarity.
- **Audiation first.** Hear it in your mind, and in your spirit, before your fingers find it.

A NOTE ON STREAKS

Streaks celebrate consistency — they do not measure your worth. If a streak breaks, the next session simply begins a new one. There is no failing this. There is only *return*. The mercy is new every morning, and so is the invitation. **Show up today, even if today is the day after a long silence.**

The Ear Comes First

Every musical skill that lasts is built on the ear. The fingers serve the ear. The hand serves the ear. The voice serves the ear. When the ear knows what it wants, the hand learns faster than seems possible.

ON AUDIATION · EDWIN E. GORDON

"Audiation is to music what thought is to speech." The ability to hear and comprehend music inside your mind — without an instrument, without a recording — is the seed of every musical skill that follows.

ON EAR TRAINING · JULIAN BRADLEY

"Ear training is the most essential skill for every musician to work on. All musicians can learn it — they just have to practice it the right way."

CONSISTENCY CARRIES THE HEART

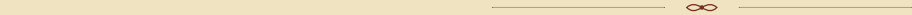
The heart is the reason we play. But hearts have weather — some days full, some days flat. Consistency is the gentle discipline that carries us across the flat days until the fullness returns. It is not a taskmaster. It is a friend that keeps the door open.

"Sing to the LORD a new song; sing to the LORD, all the earth! Sing to the LORD, bless his name; tell of his salvation from day to day."

— PSALM 96:1–2

"Small disciplines repeated with consistency every day lead to great achievements gained slowly over time."

— JOHN C. MAXWELL



Three Truths Worth Carrying

 The Small-Weight Principle

A light weight lifted every day will outbuild a heavy weight lifted once a week. The same is true on the fretboard. Ten minutes daily moves the needle in a way ninety minutes on Saturday cannot — tissue, neural pathway, finger memory are all built by gentle repetition, not by strain. Be kind to your hands; they are learning.

 The Gift of Small Time

There is more time than it seems. A week holds one hundred sixty-eight hours; ten minutes a day is barely one percent of them. The question is never "do I have time?" but "where, in this day God has given, does the guitar get to live?" Even a few minutes, offered faithfully, add up to something that surprises you.

 Habit Holds the Heart

Some days you'll feel the music; some days you won't. That's normal, and it's not a problem. A gentle habit is what carries you on the days motivation is quiet — it keeps you in the room until the joy returns. The habit isn't the point. It's the path that keeps leading back to the point.

The Ability Tree

Every musician grows along five intertwined branches. Each lesson, each rep, each song touches one or more of them. The branches grow together — strength in one feeds the others.

 Ear Tuning Pitch awareness Relative pitch Hearing changes Audiation	 Fretting Hand Chord shapes Transitions Scales Finger independence Pressure control	 Rhythm Strumming Timing Consistency Metronome work Feel & groove	 Language Tabs Chord charts Nashville numbers Keys & intervals Song structure	 Songcraft Riffs Full songs Dynamics Worship flow Expression
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The Three Active Columns

Every chapter — every lesson — moves along three parallel lanes. This rhythm keeps the work balanced between discipline and joy, between the foundation and the song.

REPS The fundamentals. Scales, transitions, timing. The quiet daily work that builds the hand and the ear. Most XP lives here.	SONGCRAFT The why. Real songs, played with feel — even if simplified. Where reps become music. Where the heart turns on.	RIFF LAB Play. Curiosity. The melodic line that makes you grin. Boss themes, intros, hooks — the candy that earns its place.
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Levels & Titles

LEVEL	TITLE	TOTAL XP
I	Camper	0
II	Apprentice	250
III	Chord Explorer	600
IV	Rhythm Builder	1,000
V	Worship Player	1,500
VI	Songsmith	2,200
VII	Worshipper	3,000

XP, Streaks & The Return



How XP is earned

ACTION	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	XP
Daily Touch	Showed up — even 5 minutes. Tuning + one chord pass counts.	+10
Quest Lane Done (day)	15+ min through the day's lanes: warmup · anchors · song · riff. Together with the Daily Touch, that's a clean +50 day.	+40
Full Weekly Quest	Five full Quest-Lane days in a week. The streak that builds the habit.	+50
Side Quest	Tuning side quest, focused chord drill, ear-training pass. Tristan or H names it.	+50 → +75
Song Milestone	Reckless Love full song · played clean · earned in Lesson.	+150
Taking It Further 🌀	Take It All Back (+150) · C or G scale at 60 bpm (+75). Earned in Lesson.	+75 → +150
Boss Battle ✕	An in-lesson milestone with the mentor.	+250

Streak Bonuses

STREAK	MEANING	BONUS
3 days	The habit catches.	+15
7 days	A full week. The hand remembers.	+50
14 days	Two weeks. The ear starts moving.	+100
30 days	A month. Identity territory.	+250

Reward Tiers

At the close of each five-lesson arc, completion percentage unlocks a reward tier. These are *low-cost, experiential, and meaningful* — coordinated with Dad. They are scaffolding, not bribery: the music itself is the prize. Song and riff choice are part of the regular journey, not reward tiers.

TIER	DONE	REWARDS
TOP	90–100%	Plan a recital or worship performance — invite family or close friends, play two or three pieces. Favorite-activity day with Dad — go-karts, amusement park, or his choice. Custom guitar accessory — engraved strap, picks, or pickguard art.
MID	80–89%	Extra jam session with H — thirty minutes beyond the regular lesson, on something the apprentice picks. Recording session — capture the strongest take of the chapter, keep it forever. Music shop trip — visit a local shop with H or Dad, try gear, browse strings and picks.
BASE	70–79%	Custom engraved pick — your name etched on it, yours to keep. Name added to the Codex Hall of Reps — a sealed page in your codex listing chapters survived. A curated H-playlist — Spotify playlist hand-built by H to set the tone for the next chapter.
—	< 70%	No reward — but no shame. Reset, regroup, return. The quest continues; the door doesn't close.

Badges & Sigils

Earned at specific moments. Each one is a small flag planted in the journey.

First Contact First touch on the strings as an apprentice.	The Tuner Passed the Teacher's Tuning Challenge.	Chord Knot Switched G ↔ Em ten times clean.	7-Day Sunrise A full week of daily contact.
First Song A song played start to finish.	First Take Recorded a take of a song or riff.	The Capo Played a song with capo for the first time.	Boss Slayer First Boss Battle completed.

Codex Sheet

A printable record of who Tristan is becoming. Fillable by hand. Updated each lesson by H. Carried home between sessions. The paper version of the digital codex.

Tristan

APPRENTICE · CAMPER · EDITION 0.1

MENTOR
H

LEVEL & XP

LEVEL

TITLE

I

Camper

TOTAL XP

0 / 250 XP → Apprentice

THIS WEEK'S STREAK

M

T

W

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F

S

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Mark with ✓ on practice days. Even 5 min counts.

THE FIVE BRANCHES

👂 Ear

L1

🎸 Fretting Hand

L1

🎵 Rhythm

L1

🗨️ Language

L1

🎶 Songcraft

L1

SONGS UNLOCKED

• Reckless Love · simplified

ACTIVE

• Game of Thrones · main theme riff

ACTIVE

• Take It All Back · power chords

LOCKED

BADGES EARNED

🎯 First Contact

Next: 🎸 The Tuner